



Indian
montessori
foundation

7th National Montessori Conference

SAPARYA

SERVING ONE SERVING ALL

MUMBAI, INDIA
PROGRAMME BOOKLET





SAPARYA
SERVING ONE SERVING ALL

DR. MARIA MONTESSORI



An education capable of saving humanity is no small undertaking; it involves the spiritual development of man, the enhancement of his value as an individual, and the preparation of young people to understand the times in which they live. It is not enough for education to concern itself with intellectual development alone; it must help the child to become a conscious, active participant in the life of society, working not for himself alone, but for the good of all.





SAPARYA

SERVING ONE SERVING ALL

Our conference theme Saparya originates from a Sanskrit term which means to serve.

To be sensitive to the needs of the others - this is the foundation of a compassionate and harmonious community. The Montessori environment fosters this spirit. While adults attentively serve the child's potential, the children develop an awareness of the needs of others and serve one another.

7th National
Montessori
Conference





SAPARYA
SERVING ONE SERVING ALL

HOW TO REACH THE VENUE

Venue: Hotel Sahara Star, Mumbai

Hotel Sahara Star is conveniently located near Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport, making it easily accessible from all parts of Mumbai.

By Air: The hotel is just 5 minutes from Terminal 1 and 10 minutes from Terminal 2 of the Mumbai International Airport.

By Road: Sahara Star is situated on Vile Parle East, close to the Western Express Highway. Taxis, app-based cabs, and auto-rickshaws are easily available across the city.

By Train: The nearest railway station is Vile Parle (East), approximately 10 minutes away by road.

By Metro: The nearest Metro Line 3 (Aqua Line) airport station is located close to the venue. From the station, the hotel is a short auto or taxi ride.

The nearest metro station is Airport Road Metro Station (Line 1), from where the venue is about 10–15 minutes by auto or taxi.

Parking: Ample parking space is available at the venue.





SAPARYA
SERVING ONE SERVING ALL

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NEWS ABOUT QUEST

The Unschooling Project is thriving!

The Unschooling Project at Quest has been steadily growing, not by promising shortcuts or alternatives to schooling, but by doing something far more deliberate: trusting children with their learning while holding them in a deeply supportive environment.

At the heart of the project is Self-Directed Learning (SDL), an approach that moves away from age-based expectations and rigid outcomes, and instead centres on choice, curiosity, responsibility, and reflection. These four pillars guide how learning unfolds at Quest - across ages, interests, and individual journeys.



Self-Directed Learning across age groups;

- 6-9 years: Exploring freely within carefully prepared environments.
- 9-12 years: Making choices with support and learning to reflect on what works.
- 13-15 years: Co-designing schedules, practising self-discipline, and setting boundaries.
- 16-18 years: Taking ownership of goals, pathways, and life beyond Quest.

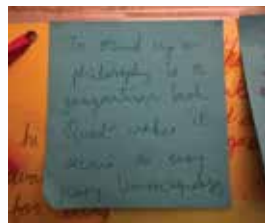
Curious? Write to us;
contact@questcommunity.in

Learning with consent, in the realm of education

Younger learners begin by exploring interests within thoughtfully prepared environments, while older learners gradually take on greater ownership of time, projects, and decisions. Facilitators, mentors and subject-matter experts, offer structure, asking reflective questions, and ensuring that learners are supported so that they can take agency. As learners grow, the focus shifts from exploration to clarity. Teenagers at Quest engage in long-term projects, internships, and skill-building aligned with their interests and identities. Certification pathways such as NIOS or Cambridge are available when they serve a learner's goals.

What has allowed The Unschooling Project to thrive is not just its philosophy, but its community. Parents, facilitators, and learners are active participants in the process, engaging in ongoing dialogue.

In a time when education is often reduced to performance metrics and rankings, Quest offers a more intentional alternative - one that measures success in curiosity sustained, responsibility practised, and young people who feel prepared not just for the next stage, but for life itself.





Association Montessori Internationale serves as a network and community that applies the principles of Montessori in many aspects of life and living, building upon the approach without compromising its integrity. As such, it is the recognised authority for those interested in applying the Montessori

approach at multiple levels—from education to humanitarian causes to research and the broader physical and social environment.

First and foremost, AMI empowers teachers and communities through the educational approach of Maria Montessori adapting it across continents and cultures to help children develop their true potential and make a difference in the world.

AMI is renowned for enabling teachers to become masters of transformative teaching by implementing the Montessori approach with the highest level of fidelity. Our teachers help children follow their interests and passions to develop strong academic and life skills, leadership, self-discipline, responsibility, and independence. AMI teachers create learning environments that are hands-on, self-paced, collaborative, and joyful—everything that's needed to create a lifelong, active learner.

AMI Montessori Teacher Certification helps teachers nurture each child into a capable and connected individual, while moving all children forward. Schools that house AMI Certified Montessori teachers reassure parents that the school supports the teacher in developing each child's full potential.





An affiliate of the Association Montessori Internationale (AMI), IMF is a pan-Indian organisation dedicated to supporting and promoting Montessori education across India. It was established in 2009 in order to create awareness about Montessori



principles and to create a common forum for anyone interested in child development. By supporting parents, teachers and schools, IMF supports children by creating an awareness of their needs at different developmental stages. IMF brings out two publications, The Touch Board and Montessori Matters, to provide information on current events, issues and trends in education. It publishes and publicises Montessori books, other journals and newsletters, educational materials and films to support the growth and strengthen the practice of Montessori education in society. It organises talks, conferences and workshops on Montessori philosophy and current issues in education to foster dialogue and discussion on social conditions affecting the child's environment among all stakeholders.

Indian Montessori Foundation organises three kinds of events – talks, workshops and conferences. The talks and workshops are held online as well as offline at various cities across India where Montessori training centres exist. The Indian National Montessori Conference is an initiative by the IMF where esteemed Montessori Trainers and distinguished experts from various fields share their insights and is organized every two years.



SAPARYA

SERVING ONE SERVING ALL

In conversation with Umashankar Kenche



Maria Montessori with Children

The theme chosen for the Seventh National Montessori Conference—Saparya—is rooted in the Sanskrit word that signifies service offered with reverence. More than a simple act of helping, Saparya conveys the spirit of a sacred offering, a gesture imbued with respect and devotion.

Within the Montessori framework the child is seen as a guide, leading us toward a meaningful way of life.

Reflecting on the essence of Montessori work, it becomes clear that everything we do is ultimately in service of the child. In Montessori environments, adults who work with the children across all age



groups, from early childhood to adolescence, offer them presentations. The developmental work presented is like a sacred offering. This led us to Saparya as the theme for the conference.

Montessori education itself is built on respect—for oneself, for others, and for the environment. From infancy onwards, children are guided to care for themselves, care for others, and care for their surroundings. This is service in its truest sense. Service also means empathy. Montessori environments nurture empathy and kindness not as abstract concepts but as lived experiences. Children learn to share without selfishness, to cooperate naturally with peers and elders, and to build responsibility toward their community. Interdependence and mutual support are woven into the Montessori philosophy. In this way, Saparya beautifully reflects the spirit of Montessori education—service, empathy, cooperation, and responsibility.

A conference provides a platform in which even a familiar idea seems new when filtered through other perspectives. We gain fresh insight into our work from listening to others. By participating in this conference, we hope that the message the participants will carry away with them is one of hope. By working together, we can inspire one another to make a positive impact in the lives of children. This is not for our personal or professional development — it is for the child, for peace, and for the betterment of the world. If we create a nurturing

environment that meets the needs of children, we serve all human society.

We believe that in this conference participants will exchange ideas, seniors will learn from the younger generation just as the young people will learn from the elders. We hope the spirit of Saparya ensures that the dialogue continues beyond the conference venue, in newsletters, in bulletins, in journals, in conversations, to help us to reflect and to inform our everyday practice. In this way, the theme becomes not just a word, but a living principle—service with reverence, offered to the child, who is both our responsibility and our guide.



Kenche Umasbankar holds a B.Sc. in Home Science from Sri Satya Sai Institute of Higher Learning, a postgraduate degree in Literature, and bachelor's degrees in Education and Child

Psychology from Osmania University. She has completed three AMI Diplomas in Montessori education, specializing in the 3–6, 6–12, and 12–18 age groups, along with an assistant certificate in Infancy. In 1998, she founded Samagna Montessori House of Children in Hyderabad, creating a nurturing environment for learners from toddlers to adolescents. She has also volunteered with Educateurs sans Frontières in Andhra Pradesh and contributed as a lesson planner for Sri Satya Sai Vidya Vabini. ✦





RECLAIMING PEACE THROUGH ATTENTIVE SERVICE

By Suneeta Madnani

A search for the meaning of the Sanskrit term 'Saparya' throws up the idea of service and extends further, to qualify this act as an 'attentive' honouring of something divine.

We, at the IMF, bring to you on the 23rd and 24th of January 2026, a diverse narrative on why this attitude of 'attentive service' must be a part of our relationship with the child.

Service is not something that needs to be done but it is a characteristic of life itself. To live is to serve. Is this relevant today? How does this principle inform our everyday life? What do we need to do to begin to align with this idea? What is the role of this idea in education?

Swami Vivekanand in a talk on Karma Yoga, spoke of the struggle towards freedom. Freedom not in reference to India, which was not yet a nation then, but to the urge of life itself.

"Everything that we perceive around us is struggling towards freedom... The whole

universe is in fact a result of this struggle for freedom....

It is the groundwork of all morality, of unselfishness...

...When we see a man doing good work, helping others, it means he cannot be confined within the limited circle of "me and mine". There is no limit to this getting out of selfishness".

In her writing, Montessori draws our attention to service as a constantly moving wheel powered by the energy of life. Defining life as a creative energy that serves the planet continuously making it evolve and, in turn, being affected by its evolution to become more creative, she celebrates the coming of man as a new energy – a powerful force - a conscious form of love. Her idea of the Four Planes of Development explores the evolution of this energy from conception to 24 years of age - an energy that can become individuated only within the community. This is where the theme of the Conference sits.



Within the child – who is not yet an adult – lies the unselfishness that the human soul craves. She offers the idea of the vastness of his 'absorbent mind', an accepting mind, a non discriminatory mind – a mind that comes clothed in LOVE, as the solution to all of humanities problems. Within the child's way of engaging with the world lies peace and harmony. The child who is not yet confined within the circle of 'me and mine', must lead the way. And this is what Montessori education is about.

All science according to Swami Vivekanand is an expression of this search for freedom from the bonds of selfishness. Humanity's struggle to free itself from the bonds of selfishness, must according to Montessori begin with knowing and becoming engulfed by the love of the child. But to know him we must serve him. Like a scientist serving life in his petri dish, attentively, we must serve the child.

Work as service is what the child already understands – in his way of living we see the universal desire for freedom from selfishness. Montessori environments acknowledge this power. They are spaces designed to attentively serve this very human way of engaging with the world – with love, through work. Education, according to Montessori, must be an attempt to draw out this love, to serve it, to allow the hands of the child access to the implements that make the mind human.

The struggle of the child towards becoming human must be understood and served. When the adult begins to think he can shape this becoming, we find the first seeds of all human conflict sown. When the adult begins to do for the child everything he

can't do, we are looking at the first act of disservice. Can we serve the child's incapability? Can we become nonviolent – can education be a science in which the child reveals everyday more and more secrets about what it means to be human?

'Saparya', over the 2 days of the Conference, reflects on this idea of attentive service, of following the child. Through the voices of experienced Montessorians who have been shown the way by the children they served and through the voices of people who have spent their lives serving children, we will look at how humanity can become peaceful, at how we can reclaim our role as the centre piece in the arch of creation through attentive service to the peace within the child.



Suneeta Madnani holds a Bachelor's degree in Literature, Economics, and Psychology. She began her Montessori journey in Mumbai in 1997, earning her AMI Primary Diploma at RTI.

Over 13 years at Casa Bambino and Activity Infant School, her passion for Montessori deepened, leading to certification as an AMI Trainer in 2016.

She has served as faculty at AMI Training Centers in India and China, and as National and AMI Examiner in India and abroad. She is currently faculty at the Ratan Tata Montessori Primary Teacher Training Course. Since 2015 she has been the Editor of Montessori Matters, the journal published by the Indian Montessori ✦



SERVING LIFE, HUMANITY

By Uma Ramani

Saparya signifies attentive service offered with deep respect and care that honors the spirit. The concept of *Saparya* succinctly captures the essence of our practice of Aid to Life. Montessori writes about the Guide, "They are to serve, and to serve well; to serve the spirit." Let us analyze this.

The Guide pauses at the door to the Casa. They put away their bag, change out of outdoor footwear and let the bustle and cares of the morning slip to the back of the mind preparing to step into the routines of the day. Their pace slows as they walk around the room, touching, straightening, ensuring that everything is neat, clean and orderly and that each material is ready for use. They set up their space with planning, observation and record-keeping documents and review the plans for the day ahead. Centered, they move to the doorway to welcome the children. As they greet each child, they get a sense of their energy – they share the excitement of the child who has visiting grandparents; they marvel at the smoothness of a rock another child has picked up; they comfort a child who has

not had a very restful night; and notice the new haircut of another. As the children slip into their work, one child chooses to stay by the guide. They offer a hand quietly as they take a moment to observe the community. Noticing a child looking with interest at a picture on the wall the guide walks over for a conversation, sharing observations about the picture. As they move on, the guide offers another child a point of consciousness in the organization of their material. They notice that there is some laundry to be folded and invite

*In serving the child,
one serves life; in
helping nature one
rises to the next
stage, that of
super-nature, for to
go upwards is the
law of life.*





the child who is still with them to help in the work. As the child becomes engaged in the folding, the guide quietly moves on. Through the day, the guide is aware of each child in the community, being available when needed, connecting them to the environment and the community, offering necessary and sufficient help and then withdrawing to the background. The movements are economical and precise, their voice quiet, their demeanor warm and joyful as they work to serve each child in their work of self-construction, singing songs, sharing stories, and offering presentations to engage children according to their needs and interests

on that day. A child's need for rest is honored, as is the need to work with another child, to talk and move. The guide unobtrusively ensures order and engages the children in the care of the environment and the community. The guide maintains notes on their activities and the activities of the children. And as the day winds to a close, they bid farewell to each child, ensure that all is in order in the environment and before they leave, pause to reflect on the day.

In reviewing the day in the life of a guide in the Casa, we see that the concept of Saparya is woven into the daily practice of Aid to Life.

Steadfast: There is a deep commitment to serve the needs of the child through the environment and the activities and by facilitating the activity of the child. This constancy makes the guide trustworthy and reliable.

Attentive: Careful observation allows for caring, thoughtful, respectful preparation, anticipation and response that is offered "without disclosing itself or, when it is discovered, it poses not as a help, but as something natural and spontaneous." It is help offered, never imposed.

Prepared: The preparation of the guide for such work is a process of self-formation and itself becomes an act of service. "We have to help the child to act, will and think for himself. This is the art of serving the spirit...." And this service is manifested in the careful preparation of the environment, the planning and implementation.



Affectionate: Love and caring permeates every action and interaction and the discipline that is practiced by the adult. "...the real help ... comes from subjecting one's love to discipline, using it with discernment..."

Reflective: Every action is the result of careful thought and thus responsive and not reactive. A necessary corollary to observation, reflection is "A habit which must be developed with practice." Such reflection allows mindful action.

Montessori writes that when observation stirs the spirit "...the student and the subject of study can be fused together", and it calls forth activity that becomes a collaboration with the child.

Yogic: Body, mind and spirit are united in every action and interaction. Actions move beyond the external technique to emotional, intellectual and spiritual connection "She will be able to say: "I have served the spirits of those children, and they have fulfilled their development, and I kept them company in their experiences."

Accepting: Acceptance comes from faith in the intrinsic motivators and the trust that the practice of the method will free innate constructive energies. Acceptance is not conditional, it embraces every child as they are, seeing them as they can be. "On this level, justice is something truly spiritual; it tries to ensure that every child shall make the best of himself. Justice, here, is to give every human being the help he needs to bring about his fullest spiritual

stature, and service of the spirit at every age means helping those energies that are at work to bring this about."

"In serving the child, one serves life; in helping nature one rises to the next stage, that of super-nature, for to go upwards is the law of life." Thus, in serving the child, "It is the teacher who feels she has been lifted to a height she never knew before. The child has made her grow till she is brought within his sphere."

In Montessori practice, then, Saparya becomes "for the service of living humanity."



Uma Ramani
completed her AMI
3-6 training in
Hyderabad in 1980
under Mr. A.M.
Joosten and Mr. S.R.
Swamy, both trained
by Dr. Maria
Montessori. She also

holds the AMI 6-12 Diploma and has been an AMI trainer at the 3-6 level since 2010. Since 2014, she has served as Director of Training at the Montessori Institute of North Texas, Dallas. Uma spearheaded the design of blended training and piloted the AMI 3-6 blended course in 2019. She also designed the EsF Community Rooted Education program and continues to explore the relevance of Montessori philosophy in today's context. ✦



PROGRAMME SCHEDULE

FRIDAY, JANUARY 23, 2026

TIMINGS	DAY 1
7:30 AM	REGISTRATION & STALL OPEN
9:00 AM	WELCOME - CHIEF GUEST - <i>DIA MIRZA</i> KEY NOTE - <i>NANDITA DAS</i>
10:00 AM	ME, MYSELF AND OTHERS - <i>IRENE FAFALIOS</i> (AMI 3-6 TRAINER, GREECE)
11:00 AM	COFFEE BREAK
11:30 AM	EDUCATION FOR LIFE - <i>NEELIMA MHASKAR</i> (AMI 3-6 TRAINER, INDIA)
12:15 PM	LUNCH
1:45 PM	A TRAINER'S LIFE - <i>IN CONVERSATION WITH ZARIN MALVA</i> (AMI 3-6 TRAINER, INDIA)
2:30 PM	COFFEE BREAK
3:00 PM	MONTESSORI FOR COMMUNITY - <i>JENNY HÖGLUND</i> (AMI 6 - 12 & 12-18 TRAINER, SWEDEN)
4:00 PM	SERVING THE FUTURE ✦ VALORIZATION IN ORBIT - AN ADOLESCENT CUBESAT MISSION BY BLUE BLOCK ADOLESCENTS ✦ GATEWAY TO DIPLOMACY BY ANTHEA MONTESSORI/MMUN ✦ MUMBAI'S TIFFIN'S HEROS - CARRIERS OF TRUST BY DA VINCI SCHOOL ✦ BECOMING BY HARMONY SCHOOL



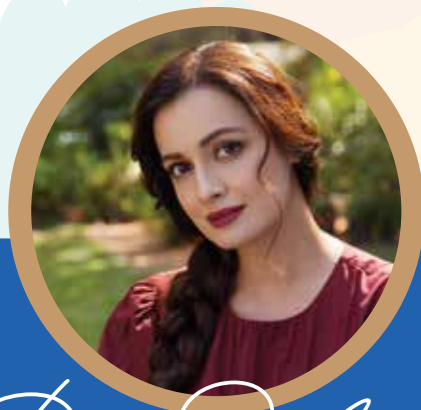
PROGRAMME SCHEDULE

SATURDAY, JANUARY 24, 2026

TIMINGS	DAY 2
8:00 AM	REGISTRATION & STALL OPEN
9:00 AM	KEY NOTE: <i>ANURADHA SHANKAR</i>
10:00 AM	MONTESSORI'S COSMIC VISION - <i>REBECCA DALLAM</i> (AMI 6-12 TRAINER, AUSTRALIA)
11:00 AM	COFFEE BREAK
11:30 AM	COMMUNITY SERVICE IN EDUCATION - <i>DR. YOGESH KULKARNI</i> (EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR: VIGYAN ASHRAM, INDIA)
12:15 PM	LUNCH
1:45 PM	MONTESSORI BEYOND THE CLASSROOM (PANEL) <i>ANURADHA SHANKAR, DR. YOGESH KULKARNI, GEETA SUBHEDAR, THOMMEN OLLAPALLY, SACHINKUNMAR RATHOD, CAROLINE PAUL</i>
2:45 AM	COFFEE BREAK
3:15 PM	SERVING ONE, SERVING ALL - <i>TEENAZ REPORTER</i> (AMI 3-6 TRAINER, INDIA)
4:15 PM	VALEDICTORY - <i>VOTE OF THANKS - TRUSTEES</i>



CHIEF GUEST



Dia Mirza

ACTOR

Named among 100 influential and inspiring women from across the world in the BBC 100 Women List 2023, Dia Mirza plays diverse and multifaceted roles as a climate champion, the founder of production house One India Stories and as an actor. In 2024, Dia was also awarded the Wildlife Advocate of the Year award at the 24th annual Animal Action Awards held in London for her contributions to animal welfare, rescue, or conservation. As the UN Environment Goodwill Ambassador & United Nations Secretary General's Advocate for Sustainable Development Goals and in every other capacity, Dia remains deeply interested in the human condition, the interconnectedness of all living beings, gender issues, social parity and a sustainable relationship between humanity and the planet.



KEYNOTE SPEAKER



Nandita Das

ACTOR, FILMMAKER, WRITER AND SOCIAL ADVOCATE

Nandita Das is an actor, filmmaker, writer and social advocate, deeply committed to children's education and social justice. She holds a Master's degree in Social Work from Delhi University and since then has continued to engage with child rights, inclusive education and human development. After graduation, she taught a term at Rishi Valley school. Her early involvement with NGOs such as Alarippu focused on joyful learning and teaching for underprivileged schools. During her tenure as Chairperson of the Children's Film Society, India, she revitalised the organisation to promote meaningful, child-centric cinema. Alongside her advocacy, she has had a distinguished career in cinema, acting in over 40 films and directing critically acclaimed films - Firaq, Manto, and Zwigato.



KEYNOTE SPEAKER



Anuradha Shankar

AMI BOARD MEMBER

Anuradha Shankar, born into a family deeply involved in India's Freedom Movement, embodies Gandhian values of non-violence and ethical citizenship. A decorated senior officer of the Indian Police Service, she has championed safety and justice for women and children while leading governance oversight with critical analysis and reform. Actively engaged with Ekta Parishad and Jai Jagat, she mentors youth on building non-violent economies and community harmony. She has collaborated with UNICEF on child-friendly policing and programme evaluation, and serves on the board of the Universal Solidarity Movement. Internationally, she speaks on Kasturba Gandhi and women's role in India's freedom struggle.



SPEAKER

IRENE
FAFALIOS



ME, MYSELF AND OTHERS

AMI 3-6 TRAINER, GREECE

IRENE will delve into how children build their sense of self through social interactions, uncovering the dynamic link between individual growth and social connection. From early interactions, children develop a social sense, learning to relate, cooperate, and belong – laying the groundwork for a confident, connected adulthood.

Irene Fafalios (M.A. Social Anthropology, AMI Diploma. 0-3, 3-6, 6-12, EsF) lives and works in Athens, Greece, where in 2002 she set up The Montessori Institute, Greece (formerly The Montessori Lab). Over the last 20 years, she has worked to establish Montessori in mainland Greece and now, together with the growing team at the Institute, they are extending their work to the islands and supporting their students as they Montessori into practice both in the classroom and beyond, Irene Fafalios is an AMI Trainer (3-6) and an International lecturer and Examiner for AMI.



SPEAKER

NEELIMA MBASKAR



EDUCATION FOR LIFE

AMI 3-6 TRAINER, INDIA

Dr. Montessori believed the young child needs to be educated for life. Education involves nurturing qualities within a person and drawing forth their innate potential. The young child has to be educated to live his life. Neelima will shed light on how living a full life requires one to be independent on the physical, social and emotional level, be able to make choices, persevere with one's choices, take responsibility for it, be self-aware, confident, socially developed, be a lifelong learner and be at peace with oneself and the world around.

Neelima Mbaskar, an AMI Primary Trainer, earned her diploma in 1989 under Ms Zarin Malva and became a certified trainer in 2016. She has over 19 years of experience working with children and has also completed certificate courses at 0-3 and 6-12 levels. She has served on training teams across India and China, and has conducted over 30 AMI Certificate Courses in India, China, Taiwan, and Vietnam and 2 Foundation Courses. Neelima has also served as a National and AMI Examiner. She is currently a faculty member at the course in Beijing and Director of Training at AMI Montessori Chinese Taipei Centre and Vivek High Montessori Institute. She enjoys travel and nature.



SPEAKER

ZARIN MALVA



A TRAINER'S LIFE

AMI 3-6 TRAINER, INDIA

The life of our senior trainer, Ms. Zarin Malva, has been a journey in service to the community—it's a legacy of service, dedication, and inspiration. In a candid conversation, we'll explore her profound insights of the Montessori philosophy and the lifelong commitment she has made to nurturing children, guiding educators, and shaping communities.

Zarin Malva obtained her AMI 3-6 Diploma and taught for many years in India, Canada and the U.S. After many years of work with children, she then became an AMI 3-6 trainer and returned to Mumbai, her native city, as an AMI trainer in 1987. In 1988 the JMS Montessori Training Course was established in Mumbai and then in 1998, Ms. Zarin Malva was invited to run the AMI training course at the prestigious location of Sir Ratan Tata Institute. Ms. Malva had worked abroad under senior AMI trainers – Ms. Estela Palmieri and Ms. Hilla Patell. She also worked for a year under Mr. S. R. Swamy, the then AMI Trainer of the Indian Montessori Training Course. Ms. Malva brings to her work her rich and varied experience with children. Besides her excellent work in the field of teacher education, she also guides and supports the staff of the Montessori schools in the city.



SPEAKER

JENNY
HÖGLUND



MONTESSORI FOR COMMUNITY

AMI 6-12 & 12-18 TRAINER, SWEDEN

Adolescence is a formative stage of life in which young people come to understand how their actions matter in the world. Maria Montessori recognised that the sense of service adolescents offer—to themselves, to others, and to the planet—depends deeply on the experiences they are given. When adolescents are trusted with real responsibility, meaningful work, and life in community, they develop respect, collaboration, and a belief that they can make a difference. Montessori's vision places adolescents within the real workings of society, where shared work, contribution, and moral purpose foster independence and prepare them to serve their communities and the wider world.

Jenny Marie Höglund is an AMI trainer at the 6–12 and 12–18 levels, with a Master's in Education and decades of experience. In 1995, she founded a Montessori school near Göteborg, Sweden, serving children aged 1–12 and, later, adolescents through The Montessori Centre for Work and Study. Her pioneering work with adolescents has shaped the Montessori approach to this developmental stage. Since 2003, Jenny has contributed to the AMI-NAMTA Orientation to Adolescent Studies, bringing the living philosophy of Erdkinder to life. She is known for her rigorous practice, deep expertise, and unwavering support for students during and beyond their training.



SERVING THE FUTURE

Blue Blocks Montessori School,
Hyderabad

Valorization in Orbit: An Adolescent CubeSat Mission

Witness the valorization of the adolescent personality through purposeful, real-world work. Blue Blocks adolescents undertook the full lifecycle of a CubeSat mission, engaging with domain experts as part of their prepared environment. Assuming real responsibility within a collaborative adolescent community, they navigated complexity, uncertainty, and accountability while working in service of a technological future.

Anthea Montessori School/MMUN,
Hyderabad
Gateway to Diplomacy

The presentation offers a firsthand perspective on the Montessori Model United Nations (MMUN), a global citizenship program grounded in peace education and collaboration. Student delegates share their experiences and learning, highlighting how MMUN fostered confidence, critical thinking, communication, and a deep sense of global responsibility through cooperation, empathy, and meaningful dialogue.

Da Vinci Montessori,
Mumbai

Mumbai's Tiffin Heroes - Carriers of Trust

Discover the 'Mumbai's tiffin heroes'! This performance highlights the importance of honesty, punctuality, and dedication displayed by them. Each lunchbox is handled with care, showcasing responsibility in small tasks that build greatness in life. It showcases the idea that success isn't just about big machines or education, but about strong values and commitment.

Harmony Montessori International,
Mumbai
Becoming

Becoming is a contemporary dance piece that explores growth, responsibility, and conscious choice. Through fluid movement and moments of stillness, the dancers reflect the transition from being guided by their environment to consciously contributing to it. The work embodies service to the future through awareness, courage, and collective becoming.



SPEAKER

REBECCA DALLAM



MONTESSORI'S COSMIC VISION

AMI 6-12 TRAINER, AUSTRALIA

As per Dr. Montessori' Cosmic Vision, the universe is an intricate web of life, where all forms of life are interconnected, interdependent, and one. Rebecca will examine the transformative power of this cosmic vision and how, by embracing this vision, children can develop a deeper understanding of their place within the universe and their role in fostering a more harmonious world.

Rebecca Dallam is Director of Elementary Training at Sydney Montessori Training Centre. She holds AMI 3-6 (1987) and 6-12 (1996) diplomas, a B.A in English literature from Temple University, and an M.Ed. in Montessori education from Loyola University. After working in U.S. public Montessori schools, she moved to Australia in 1998 and helped establish AMI 6-12 training there. Rebecca has taught across 3-12 age levels in both countries and trained educators, parents, and administrators in over a dozen nations, including Brazil, India, Japan, and Ukraine. Her work reflects a deep commitment to Montessori education and global outreach.



SPEAKER

**DR. YOGESH
KULKARNI**



**COMMUNITY SERVICE
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Vigyan Ashram follows Mahatma Gandhi's idea of education, using productive work as a medium of education. This approach resonates with contemporary educational practices such as design thinking and STEM education and is well aligned with the vision of NEP 2020 and NCF-SE 2023. Vigyan Ashram supports compulsory school-based vocational education from Grade 6 onwards as per NEP2020. Through community-linked projects across various forms of work, students learn by doing. Working with over 1,000 schools across India. Vigyan Ashram demonstrates how community service strengthens curricular learning, develops 21st-century skills, and makes education relevant, contextual, and impactful. Dr. Yogesh Kulkarni will enlighten us further regarding the work done at Vigyan Ashram and will shed light on all the ways rural technology and community service weaved into education can uplift and empower entire communities.

Dr. Yogesh Kulkarni, a Mechanical Engineer, leads rural innovation at Vigyan Ashram, Pabal, where he runs a Fab Lab for digital fabrication since 2002. He trains youth to launch tech-based village enterprises and heads the Design Innovation Centre with Savitribai Phule Pune University. He scaled the 'Introduction to Basic Technology' program to 200+ schools across four Indian states and oversees Atal Tinkering Labs in Andhra Pradesh and Karnataka. He also leads STEM initiatives in government schools in U.P., West Bengal, and Jharkhand, and serves on national committees promoting vocational education in middle and secondary schools.



PANEL DISCUSSION



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SPEAKER

TEENAZ REPORTER



SERVING ONE, SERVING ALL

AMI 3-6 TRAINER, INDIA

Service is a principle deeply embedded in Montessori pedagogy. In nature, every biotic and abiotic element fulfils its role, and in doing so, serves the whole. This

service is selfless, unconscious, and rooted in interdependence. It is this quiet offering that creates balance and harmony in the world around us.

Teenaz will throw light on how it is imperative that our children are offered an education that enables them to not only experience this service but also realise their potential to be of service to the world they live in.

When children understand their place in this interconnected web of life, service becomes a natural expression of who they are—serving one, and in doing so, serving all.

Teenaz Reporter is an AMI Primary Trainer at the 3–6 age level with over 26 years of experience in Montessori Education. She holds a Bachelor's degree in Commerce and an AMI Primary Diploma from Hyderabad, India. Teenaz has taught in both India and the U.S. She currently serves as the Director of Training at the Montessori Training and Research Trust and is on the faculty of AMI courses in China. Teenaz is passionate about raising awareness and making Montessori education more accessible to a wider demographic. Outside of her professional work, Teenaz enjoys music and travel.



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Sonia R

3-6 guide, Sports Coordinator
Vidyanjali Academy For Learning



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INSIDE PEP SCHOOLV2

*Learning Real Work through Enterprise in our
Montessori Middle School*



Maria Montessori described adolescence as a time when the young person must begin to enter the world of adult work. She proposed that schools for this age group should include opportunities for real economic activity, such as managing a small farm, store, or any other small business. As she wrote, **"The shop, the workroom, the garden, are not merely occupations; they are environments where the adolescent experiences the meaning of life through real work."**

In our Montessori Adolescent Program, this vision comes alive through **StarCrafts** and **StarScents**, student-run enterprises by our 6th and 7th graders. Like any real business, rhythms emerge: quieter weeks of steady production and planning, intense bursts as sales days approach, and natural ebbs afterward.

The purpose remains clear: adolescents discover what adult work actually feels like, collaborating, identifying how they can contribute, and doing so sustainably. Inspired, we brought a couple of looms into the classroom and began experimenting with weaving. After discussions, the first student enterprise **StarCrafts** was born. Many had already learned crochet in their elementary school days; now they honed their weaving skills more seriously, creating trial scarves and refining their technique before formally launching in February 2025.

In some domains, the maturity was striking. Students built their own website, planning product catalogues and organising photo shoots. A new batch of adolescents in June brought fresh energy and a second enterprise: **StarScents**, focused on soaps and (soon) candles. Students researched soap-making and experimented with recipes. They sourced materials, then set prices through group discussions about costs, effort, and fair profit margins. The school provided initial capital; now, students reinvest their sales income.

Adolescents formed three teams (Production, Communication, and Operations) based on their preferences, with everyone spending time in Production first to understand the work. Adults established basic structures such as safety norms, production plans, and bookkeeping, then stepped into a consulting role, leaving daily decisions to students.



Their first customers were parents. "Parents will come to school, and their children will ask them to buy!" the adolescents joked while planning their first sale.

They struggled to meet deadlines and had to apologise to customers. In **StarScents**, one early soap batch melted at room temperature; students had to investigate why and adjust their formula. At times, they ran out of materials when demand exceeded forecasts and scrambled for alternatives. Different strengths emerged: meticulous handwork, flair for design, ease in talking to unfamiliar adults, or calm coordination behind the scenes.

Behind the scenes, we see quieter shifts: students who once hesitated to speak to adults now explain products confidently; others discover they enjoy writing product descriptions or social media posts. Through **StarCrafts** and **StarScents**, our adolescents experience the full cycle of work: learning a skill, practising until it becomes craftsmanship, offering it to real customers, and reflecting on what to do differently next time.



Student Highlights

IME Inter-School Music Competition: Our team secured the **2nd runner-up** position in the Junior Category (Grades 1-5).

Aerobic Gymnastics Championships: One student from the 9-11 years category won a **silver medal** at the All Age Group Aerobic National Championship and a **gold medal** at the State Championship.

NLF Reading Challenge: Two teams from Grades 4-6 qualified for the **second round** out of **500+ teams**.

Young Mathematical Story Authors Competition (YMSA, 8-11 years category): One student was **shortlisted for the 2025 Stuart J. Murphy Award**, and two students were **longlisted** out of **750+ entries**.

Football: Two students were **selected to play** in the B Division Football team representing Karnataka.



Announcement

We've recently launched our **AI-powered Montessori Parenting Guide** — a simple, supportive way for families to bring Montessori into everyday life. Also, explore our new **YouTube series**, which offers a glimpse into our four programs & other Montessori-related content. Head to our channel **@Pep Schoolv2** to watch the full videos!

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3-6 years

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Elementary

6-12 years

Centres: HSR Layout, Whitefield, Varthur, Kokapet (Hyd)



Adolescent

12-15 years

Centres: HSR Layout, Whitefield

UPCOMING EVENTS

JAN

LIVE CLASSROOM OBSERVATIONS

January, 2026

FEB

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